Degenerate imperialism

At 10.00 am EDT, Wednesday, 24 October, the United States Navy began ‘a strict naval quarantine of all offensive military equipment’ headed to Cuba, and, with the US Tactical Air Command (TAC), stood ready to launch hundreds of air strikes against targets in Cuba. US naval, airborne, and amphibious forces prepared for an invasion. Some 90,000 troops would take the island. The airborne divisions that landed in Normandy – the 101st and 82nd – would lead the assault, with the Fifth Marine Expeditionary Brigade, followed by the 1st Armoured Division, the 1st and 2nd Infantry Divisions. Three (later six) US aircraft carriers led the naval deployment, which included twenty-five (later forty-three destroyers).[5]

During the crisis, the United States Navy deployed 183 warships and 85,000 men, including 40,000 marines. The USAF and the USN deployed over 2,000 aircraft and the air force mobilised 148,000 airmen. On the first day of the attack, 1190 sorties were to be flown by 579 aircraft. All told, a quarter of a million US servicemen were ready for battle. The Pentagon anticipated some 18,500 US casualties (killed, wounded, and missing). This underestimated the size and composition of Soviet forces. US planners were unaware of the deployment of 35,000 Soviet combat troops. And the Pentagon did not know there were around one hundred tactical nuclear weapons waiting for them.

Late on 23 October, President Kennedy received a letter from Premier Khrushchev describing his actions as ‘outright banditry, or, if you like, the folly of degenerate imperialism.’[6] More ominously, he declared, that the US action was:

> an act of aggression, pushing mankind toward the abyss of a world missile-nuclear war. Consequently, the Soviet Government cannot give instructions to the captains of Soviet vessels bound for Cuba to observe the instructions of the American naval forces blockading that island. Our instructions to Soviet mariners are strictly to observe the generally recognised norms of navigation in